

What's Up, Doc?

Earlier this year, Google bought Writely, an online word processor, which has now become Google Docs. The word processor itself isn't monumentally great, but you get all the basic functionality you need and it's quite easy to use. One feature we'd like to have seen is the ability to embed or integrate with Spreadsheets; for now we must wait and watch.

Here too, due attention has been paid to collaboration, letting two or more people work on the document in real time.

Collaborators you choose can invite other collaborators as well; this could result in a potentially chaotic situation, so do watch who you invite. You can also invite people to just view your document, or alternatively publish it to the web for all to see. You can also publish the document to your blog.

Then there's the Revisions tab, which lets you track the changes that have been made to the documents, and who made them—quite essential.

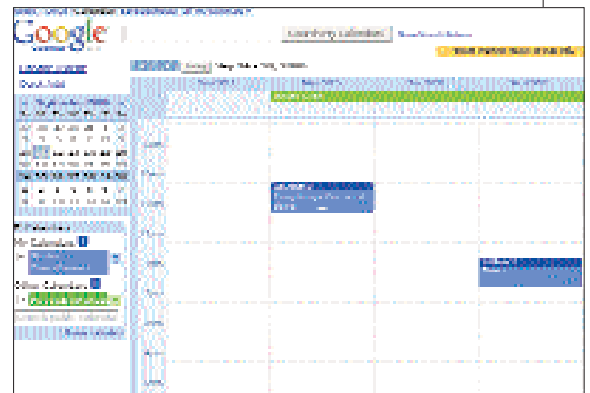
Docs and Spreadsheets now have a common home page, and you can manage, share or unshare them in a simple Gmail-like interface.

I'm Free, You're Free?

Most people who use Outlook don't take advantage of its calendar the way they should, simply because the features remain unusable unless you're on a local domain with a Microsoft Exchange Server—an expensive proposition for small and medium businesses. You can not only schedule meetings, but even view when the rest of your team is free and make plans accordingly. With Google Calendar, you now have these features within your grasp. You can create your own calendar with events and appointments with the same ease that you can in Outlook itself, perhaps even more. Creating a new meeting or appointment is as simple as clicking on the day or time-slot and entering the name of the event.

As with Spreadsheet, Calendar's best features lie in sharing. You can share your calendar in different ways—either show everyone what you're doing and when you're doing it, or just show them when you're free and busy. You can also invite specific people to manage and edit the events on your calendar—let your boss manage your meetings, perhaps? All your calendars (your own as well as ones that are shared with you) come colour-coded, so it's easy to differentiate between events.

Calendar integrates with Gmail, so when you send someone an invitation to an event, they can add it to their calendars in an instant. Google also offers you a code snippet you can add to your site, which visitors can use to add an event you create to



View multiple calendars in Google Calendar

their own calendars. Visit www.google.com/googlecalendar/event_publisher_guide.html to generate that code. Overall, Calendar is tremendously useful if you spend a lot of time online, and works best if you have Google Talk turned on—otherwise you might just end up missing that appointment reminder.

The Complete Online Office?

Adventnet (www.adventnet.com) has developed the Zoho Online Office (www.zoho.com), which consists of Zoho Show—the presentation program, Zoho Sheet—the spreadsheet application, Zoho Writer—the word processor, and Zoho Planner—an online organiser. You need

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